



NOVA

FOOD TRAILER

FOOD TRAILER STARTUP CHECKLIST

Everything You Need to Launch Your Food Trailer Business in Texas

Use this checklist to make sure you have everything in place before opening day. Requirements may vary by city and county — always confirm with your local authorities.

Nova Food Trailer: Nova Food Trailer provides your fully built, equipped, and wrapped trailer. This checklist covers everything else you need to get operational.

1 BUSINESS FORMATION

- ☐ **Choose a business structure (LLC, Sole Proprietorship, etc.)**
Form your entity with the Texas Secretary of State or file a DBA (Assumed Name Certificate) with your county clerk.
- ☐ **Obtain an EIN (Employer Identification Number)**
Free from the IRS at irs.gov — required for taxes, bank accounts, and hiring.
- ☐ **Register for a Texas Sales Tax Permit**
Free from the Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts. Required to collect and remit sales tax on food sales.
- ☐ **Open a business bank account**
Keep personal and business finances separate. Bring your EIN, formation docs, and ID.

2 HEALTH & FOOD SAFETY CERTIFICATIONS

- ☐ **Food Manager Certification (e.g., ServSafe Manager)**
At least one certified Food Manager must be on-site during operations. Exam + course (~\$150–\$200). Valid for 5 years in Texas.
- ☐ **Food Handler Certificates — all employees**
Every person who handles food must complete an accredited Food Handler course within 60 days of hire. Online, ~\$10–\$15 per person. Valid for 2 years.
- ☐ **Texas Food Establishment Rules (TFER)**
Familiarize yourself with Chapter 228 of the Texas Administrative Code — the state rules that govern mobile food operations.

3 PERMITS & LICENSES

- ☐ **Mobile Food Vendor Permit (city-specific)**
Apply with your city (e.g., City of Dallas). Requires health inspection, proof of insurance, commissary letter, and fire inspection.
- ☐ **Health Permit — County Health Department**
Issued after your trailer passes a health inspection. In Dallas County: Dallas County Health & Human Services.
- ☐ **Fire Department Inspection / Fire Permit**
Your trailer must pass a fire safety inspection. Fire extinguisher(s), hood suppression system (if cooking with grease), and propane compliance are checked.
- ☐ **Zoning Compliance**
Verify that your planned vending locations allow mobile food vendors. Some areas, private lots, and events require separate permits or landlord authorization.

4 COMMISSARY / BASE OF OPERATIONS

- ☐ **Secure a Commissary Kitchen Agreement**
Texas law requires mobile food vendors to operate from a licensed commissary kitchen for food prep, storage, cleaning, and waste disposal. You need a signed commissary letter.
- ☐ **Commissary services typically include**
Overnight parking, potable water fill-up, wastewater disposal, dry/cold storage, and prep space. Costs vary (~\$300–\$800/month in DFW).

5 INSURANCE

- ☐ **General Liability Insurance**
Minimum \$1,000,000 per occurrence is standard. Covers third-party bodily injury and property damage. Most cities and events require proof of insurance.
- ☐ **Commercial Auto / Trailer Insurance**
Covers the trailer itself (collision, theft, fire) plus liability while in transit.
- ☐ **Workers' Compensation Insurance**
Required in Texas if you have employees (recommended even if not legally required for sole proprietors).
- ☐ **Product Liability Insurance**
Covers claims from foodborne illness or allergic reactions. Often bundled with general liability.

6 TRAILER REGISTRATION & VEHICLE

- ☐ **Title & Register the Trailer in Texas**
You will receive a bill of sale and VIN from Nova Food Trailer. Register at your local DMV / Tax Assessor-Collector office.
- ☐ **Tow Vehicle**
Ensure you have a vehicle rated to tow your trailer safely. Check the GVWR (Gross Vehicle Weight Rating) and tongue weight capacity.
- ☐ **Trailer Insurance (see Insurance section)**

7 EQUIPMENT & SUPPLIES (DAY-ONE ESSENTIALS)

- ☐ **Smallwares & utensils**
Spatulas, tongs, knives, cutting boards, pans, containers, portion cups, gloves, etc.
- ☐ **Disposables**
Plates, bowls, cups, napkins, bags, aluminum foil, plastic wrap, to-go containers.
- ☐ **Food thermometer(s)**
Instant-read probe thermometer — required for food safety and inspections.
- ☐ **First aid kit**
Required to be on-site during operations.
- ☐ **Cleaning supplies**
Sanitizer, degreaser, towels, trash bags, mop/broom for your area.
- ☐ **Initial food inventory**
Proteins, produce, oils, spices, sauces, dry goods — plan your menu first.
- ☐ **Propane tanks (if applicable)**
Typically 2 x 30 lb or 40 lb tanks for cooking. Keep a spare.

8 BRANDING, MENU & TECHNOLOGY

- ☐ **Design your menu**
Keep it focused (5–8 items to start). Price for profit: food cost should be 25–35% of menu price.
- ☐ **POS system / payment processing**
Square, Clover, Toast, or similar. Accept cash + card from day one.
- ☐ **Social media accounts**
Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, Google Business Profile — post your location daily.
- ☐ **Menu board / signage**
Visible, easy-to-read menu display for your serving window.

9 OPERATIONS & COMPLIANCE

- ☐ **Daily temperature logs**
Record fridge/freezer temps and hot-holding temps. Inspectors will ask for these.
- ☐ **Waste disposal plan**
Grease trap maintenance, wastewater disposal at commissary, trash removal plan.
- ☐ **Location schedule / route**
Secure 2–3 regular vending spots (private lots, office parks, breweries, events). Build a weekly schedule.
- ☐ **Event vendor applications**
Apply early to local festivals, markets, and events. Many require separate event permits + proof of insurance.

PRO TIP

Start the permit and commissary process while your trailer is being built — most applications take 2–4 weeks. That way, you can start operating as soon as your trailer is delivered.

This checklist is provided for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal, tax, or regulatory advice. Requirements vary by jurisdiction. Always verify with your local city, county, and state authorities.